temperature would be only about −18 °C (0 °F). Although the greenhouse effect is a naturally occurring phenomenon, it is intensified by the continuous emission of greenhouse gases into the atmosphere.

During the past 100 years, the amount of carbon dioxide in the atmosphere increased by roughly 30 percent and the amount of methane more than doubled.If these trends continue, the average global temperature will increase which can lead to melting of polar ice caps and flooding of low lying areas. This will increase incidence of infectious diseases like dengue, malaria etc.

15.3.1.3 Acid Rain

Rain water normally has a pH of 5.6 due to dissolution of atmospheric CO_2 into it. Oxides of sulphur and nitrogen in the atmosphere may be absorbed by droplets of water that make up clouds and get chemically converted into sulphuric acid and nitric acid respectively. As a result, pH of rain water drops below the level 5.6, hence it is called acid rain.

Acid rain is a by-product of a variety of sulphur and nitrogen oxides in the atmosphere. Burning of fossil fuels (coal and oil) in power stations, furnaces and petrol, diesel in motor engines produce sulphur dioxide and nitrogen oxides. The main contributors of acid rain are SO_2 and NO_2. They are converted into sulphuric acid and nitric acid respectively by the reaction with oxygen and water.

$$2SO_2 + O_2 + 2H_2O \rightarrow 2H_2SO_4$$

$$4NO_2 + O_2 + 2H_2O \rightarrow 4HNO_3$$

Harmful effects of acid rain:

Some harmful effects are discussed below.

(i) Acid rain causes extensive damage to buildings and structural materials of marbles. This attack on marble is termed as Stone leprosy.

$$CaCO_3 + H_2SO_4 \rightarrow CaSO_4 + H_2O + CO_2\uparrow$$

(ii) Acid rain affects plants and animal life in aquatic ecosystem.

(iii) It is harmful for agriculture, trees and plants as it dissolves and removes the nutrients needed for their growth.

(iv) It corrodes water pipes resulting in the leaching of heavy metals such as iron, lead and copper into drinking water which have toxic effects.

(v) It causes respiratory ailment in humans and animals.



Fig 15. 3. Effect Of Acid Rain On Tajmahal

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